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SECURITY



North Korean hackers blamed for record spike in crypto thefts in 2025



Hackers have stolen more than \$2 billion in crypto during the first half of 2025, according to new data from crypto analysis firm Chainalysis, marking the worst year-to-date on record for crypto thefts.

The blockchain analysis company [said Thursday in a new report](#) that the \$2.17 billion stolen during the first half of 2025 has already surpassed the amount of crypto lost last year. Not only that, the amount of cryptocurrency stolen during the first six months of 2025 was about 17% higher than the same period in 2022, which was previously the worst year on record for stolen crypto.

IMAGE CREDITS:

CHUNG SUND JON / GETTY IMAGES

Much of the stolen crypto this year was attributed to a single breach at crypto exchange Bybit, which saw [North Korean hackers steal more than \\$1.4 billion in crypto](#), much of it [subsequently laundered](#) and funneled into the North Korean regime, per [the FBI](#).

Chainalysis said the Bybit hack falls within a broader pattern of North Korean hacks, which have “become increasingly central to the regime’s sanctions evasion strategies.”

North Korea, largely cut off from the outside world and the international banking system, has become a formidable threat in recent years by targeting Western companies to steal cryptocurrency with the aim of funding its sanctioned nuclear weapons program. North Korea has also [relied on thousands](#)

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of remote IT workers, who infiltrate tech companies to earn a wage, steal intellectual property, and then extort companies into paying so as not to publish their sensitive files.

According to [an earlier Chainalysis report](#), North Korean hackers were blamed for almost two-thirds of all crypto hacks during 2024.

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North Korea-linked hackers accounted for



61% of all crypto stolen in 2024

Kate Park — 5:00 AM PST · December 19, 2024

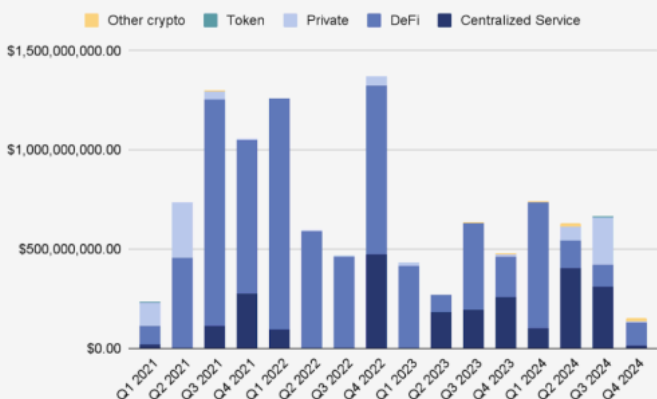
Alongside the rising adoption and value of crypto assets, theft is also on the rise. This year, the total value of cryptocurrency stolen surged 21%, reaching a substantial \$2.2 billion. And according to [a Chainalysis report](#) released on Thursday, more than half of this amount was stolen by North Korea-affiliated hacking groups.

Earlier this year, [the United Nations Security Council said](#) that North Korean hackers stole \$3 billion in cryptocurrency assets between 2017 and 2023. In 2024, hackers linked to North Korea accounted for 61% of the total amount stolen — worth \$1.34 billion, in 47 cases, per the report by Chainalysis.

IMAGE CREDITS:

SHUTTERSTOCK/ALFANCE VIA GETTY IMAGES

Amount of funds stolen by victim platform type
Q1 2021 – Q4 2024



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IMAGE CREDITS:CHAINALYSIS

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The report highlighted that most crypto hacks occurred between January and July this year, but the amount stolen had already exceeded \$1.58 billion, around 84.4% higher than the same period in 2023.

Following July, however, hacking events became significantly infrequent, potentially due to geopolitics. Chainalysis attributes it to North Korea's alliance with Russia, which emerged [after a meeting](#) between Vladimir Putin, the Russian president, and Kim Jong Un, the leader of North Korea, in June.

The amount of crypto assets stolen by North Korea-linked hackers dropped by 53.73% after the June summit, per Chainalysis. North Korea, which has increased its cooperation with Russia, might have switched up its cybercrime tactics, the report says.

Cumulative amount of funds stolen by year
2020 – 2024

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hacked in four separate years within the past decade — 2018 (\$1.5 billion), 2021 (\$3.3 billion), 2022 (\$3.7 billion), and 2023 (\$1.8 billion).

Decentralized finance (DeFi) platforms that [don't implement proper security practices](#) have been the primary targets of cryptocurrency hacks in the last three years, and accounted for the highest amount of stolen assets in Q1 2024. However, between Q2 and Q3 2024, centralized services were the main target of attacks.

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A few notable cases of centralized services that were attacked in 2024 include [DMM Bitcoin, a](#)

[Japanese crypto exchange](#) that lost \$305 million (48 billion yen) in bitcoin, and [WazirX, an Indian crypto exchange](#), which halted withdrawals in July [after a security breach by North Korea-linked hackers](#).

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Kate Park

Reporter, Asia |

Kate Park is a reporter at TechCrunch, with a focus on technology, startups and venture capital in Asia. She...

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SECURITY



North Korean hackers
exploited Chrome zero-
day to steal crypto



Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 10:13 AM PDT · August 30, 2024

A North Korean hacking group earlier in August exploited a previously unknown bug in Chrome-based browsers to target organizations with the goal of stealing cryptocurrency, according to Microsoft.

In a report published on Friday, the tech giant's cybersecurity researchers said they first saw evidence of the hackers' activities on August 19, and said the hackers were affiliated with a group called Citrine Sleet, which is known to target the crypto industry.

IMAGE CREDITS: CONTRIBUTOR / GETTY IMAGES

According to the report, the hackers exploited a flaw in a core engine within Chromium, the underlying code of Chrome and other popular browsers, like Microsoft's Edge. When the hackers exploited the vulnerability, it was a zero-day, meaning the software maker — in this case, Google — was unaware of the bug and as such had zero time to issue a fix prior to its exploitation. Google patched the bug two days later on August 21, according to Microsoft.

Google's spokesperson Scott Westover told TechCrunch that Google had no comment other than confirming that the bug was patched.

Microsoft said it has notified "targeted and compromised customers," but did not provide more

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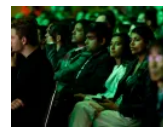


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information on who was targeted, nor how many targets and victims were targeted by this hacking campaign.

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Do you have more information about North Korean government hackers, or other government-sponsored hacking activities? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

When asked by TechCrunch, Chris Williams, a spokesperson for Microsoft, declined to say how many organizations or companies were affected.

Researchers wrote that Citrine Sleet “is based in North Korea and primarily targets financial institutions, particularly organizations and individuals managing cryptocurrency, for financial gain,” and the group “has conducted extensive reconnaissance of the cryptocurrency industry and individuals associated with it” as part of its social engineering techniques.

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“The threat actor creates fake websites masquerading as legitimate cryptocurrency trading platforms and uses them to distribute fake job applications or lure targets into downloading a weaponized cryptocurrency wallet or trading application based on legitimate applications,” reads the report. “Citrine Sleet most commonly infects targets with the unique trojan malware it developed, AppleJeus, which collects information necessary to seize control of the targets’ cryptocurrency assets.”

The North Korean hackers’ attack started by tricking a victim into visiting a web domain under the hackers’ control. Then, because of another vulnerability in the Windows kernel, the hackers were able to install a rootkit — a type of malware that has deep access to the operating system — on the target’s computer, according to Microsoft’s report.

At that point, it’s basically game over for the targeted victim’s data, as the hackers had gained complete control of the hacked computer.

Crypto has been a juicy target for North Korean government hackers for years. A United Nations Security Council panel concluded that the regime [stole \\$3 billion in crypto](#) between 2017 and 2023. Given that the Kim Jong Un government is the target of strict international sanctions, the regime has turned to stealing crypto to fund its nuclear weapons program.

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

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